SEGMENTATION · PERSONALIZATION GOVERNANCE

Why weren't students saving? Segment-aware personalization at Topman

From a hidden discount to board-level strategy — how segment signals the data could already see became visible, useful experience, governed by simplicity and a business case per deployment.

ROLE	TEAM	METHODS	OUTCOME
Personalization Specialist	Capita· Qubit ecosystem ·Topman	Segment analytics ·Real-time delivery ·Geo merchandising	Student sales hit 50% of UK sales at peak

OVERVIEW

Making the data's segments visible in the experience

Topman's data kept describing audiences that its website refused to acknowledge. Students — one of the brand's most important demographics, entitled to a 10% discount — shopped an experience where their offer was easy to miss. Regional customers browsed a product wall ranked for a national average that described nobody. The project was about closing that gap: letting what the data knew about segments become visible, useful experience — and doing it with a discipline the board could trust.

Embedded in the Arcadia ecosystem, I worked on segment-aware experiences delivered through Qubit's real-time layer, under a program philosophy of simplicity and a business case behind every deployed experience.

01 — THE TENSION

Three gaps between what the data knew and what the experience showed

1 · THE OFFER NOBODY SAW

The student discount existed — 10%, meaningful for the demographic — but availability isn't awareness. Buried in the journey, the offer didn't work in the moment of browsing, where price perception actually forms. The ecommerce team's goal was blunt and correct: make it obvious.

2 · A NATIONAL SITE FOR REGIONAL TASTES

Product performance data showed clear geographic patterns — certain products over-indexed in certain cities. The product listing page ignored all of it, ranking one national assortment for everyone. The averages looked fine; the locality signal underneath was going unused.

3 · THE LEGACY MINDSET

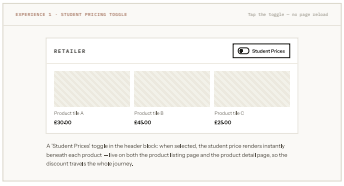
The biggest barrier wasn't technical — it was organizational habit. Personalization stalls when it's pitched as an abstract capability. The program's counter was governance: keep every experience simple, and attach a business case to each one, so that personalization stayed legible to customers and credible to the board.

> *The data already knew who was shopping. The experience just wasn't acting on it — and every day of that gap was a discount unclaimed and a relevant product unranked.*

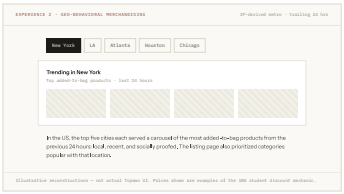
02 — THE CRAFT

Building segment-aware experiences

Four layers, each converting a known segment signal into visible experience — governed by the simplicity principle. Try the two flagship experiences below.



A 'Student Prices' toggle in the header block: when selected, the student price renders instantly beneath each product — live on both the product listing page and the product detail page, so the discount travels the whole journey.



In the US, the top five cities each served a carousel of the most added-to-bag products from the previous 24 hours. A local, recent, and socially proofed, The listing page also prioritized categories popular with that location.

3 · MOMENTUM & ORIENTATION

Supporting the edges of the journey: 'Don't miss out' banners sustaining urgency on product pages, and 'Welcome to Topman' pop-ups orienting first-time visitors.

4 · EXPERIENCE GOVERNANCE

Simplicity, and a business case per experience. Every deployment justified individually — no personalization for personalization's sake — keeping results legible enough to be discussed at board level.

03 — IMPLEMENTATION

Rigorous execution

The student toggle is a deliberate design position: **user-controlled personalization.** Rather than inferring who might be a student — fragile and presumptuous — the experience lets the segment self-identify with one tap, then rewards that identification instantly. Price is a sensitive surface; transparency beats inference on sensitive surfaces.

The geo merchandising ran on **fresh behavioral data, not static assumptions** — carousels rebuilt from the trailing 24 hours of add-to-bag activity, so "trending in Chicago" was a statement of fact about yesterday, not a merchandiser's guess about the region.

And every experience passed the governance gate first: a stated business case, a simple mechanic, a measurable outcome — the discipline that kept things simple enough to scale and credible enough for the board.

04 — THE EVIDENCE

Measuring the lift

50%
of UK sales at peak came from students — the experience contributed to driving that share

Instant
price transparency — discounted prices rendered in-session without a reload, on listing and detail pages

5 cities
behavioral/geo-merchandising — metro-level carousels built on trailing-24-hour add-to-bag data

Board-level
strategic standing — personalization discussed at board level as core to the group's customer-centric strategy

> *"The key has been to keep things simple and build a business case for each and every experience we want to deploy."*
>
> — Gareth Rees-John, Digital Director, Topman

THE GROWTH

Key learnings

Let users pull personalization
On sensitive surfaces — price above all — the best segmentation is self-identification. Inference risks being wrong or creepy; an opt-in toggle is accurate, respectful, and instantly rewarding. Personalization the user controls earns trust that personalization done to the user never can.

National averages hide local signal
The national bestseller list described no actual city. Disaggregating by metro revealed rankings the average had erased — a pattern I now look for in every dataset, because what's true of product popularity is true of most behavioral metrics.

Governance is a feature
"A business case per experience" sounds like bureaucracy; it functioned as quality control. It forced every idea to state its mechanism and its metric before launch — which is why the program compounded credibility instead of accumulating clutter. Simplicity scaled; sophistication would have stalled.

Sheeta Sharma · Quantitative UX Researcher

Segment personalization within the Arcadia Group ecosystem. Proprietary metrics generalized for confidentiality.